

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 24 Summary

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In this lesson, we explore the many uses of the Spanish mega verb **TENER** (to have), especially in expressions where English uses the verb **to be**. These are some of the most common and essential phrases for everyday Spanish and often trip up learners because the structure is so different from English. We also look at gender quirks with certain feminine nouns, review the use of *tener* with expressions of obligation and desire, and touch on how Spanish expresses heat, cold, and spiciness with different verbs. If you master this content, your Spanish will sound much more natural.

1. Obligation with *tener que* + infinitive

This construction means “to have to do something.”

Example:

Tengo que ir al parque. = I have to go to the park.

2. Possession and Questions

Example:

¿*Tienes hijos?* = Do you have children?

3. Physical Needs: Hunger and Thirst

In Spanish, these are expressed with **tener** and a noun (not *estar* and an adjective).

- *Tengo hambre.* = I'm hungry.
- *Tengo sed.* = I'm thirsty.

To say you're **very hungry/thirsty**, use **mucha** because *hambre* and *sed* are feminine nouns.

- *Tengo mucha hambre.* = I'm very hungry.
 - *Tenemos mucha sed.* = We're very thirsty.
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4. Special Rule: Feminine Nouns That Take “el” in the Singular

Some feminine nouns with a stressed **a** sound at the beginning take **el** instead of **la** in the singular to avoid awkward pronunciation. But they still behave like feminine nouns otherwise.

Examples:

- *el hambre* (but *mucha hambre*)
- *el agua* (but *las aguas*)
- *el águila* (but *las águilas*)
- *un águila* (not *una águila*)

This pattern is important for sound, not gender logic.

5. Age with *tener*

Spanish uses *tener* to express age.

Example:

- *Tengo 53 años.* = I’m 53 years old.
(Be careful: *años* must be pronounced with the ñ. *Anos* means “anuses.”)
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6. Temperature and Sensations

In Spanish, you **have** heat or cold, you don’t **be** them.

Examples:

- *Tengo calor.* = I’m hot.
 - *Tengo frío.* = I’m cold.
 - *Tengo mucho calor.* = I’m very hot.
 - *Tienen mucho frío.* = They are very cold.
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7. When Something Else Is Hot or Cold (Use *estar*)

To describe the temperature of **food, objects, or environments**, use *estar* and an adjective:

- *La comida está caliente.* = The food is hot.
- *El café está frío.* = The coffee is cold.

- *Las piedras están calientes.* = The stones are hot.

Use **muy** for emphasis here (not **mucho**):

- *El café está muy caliente.* = The coffee is very hot.
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8. Spicy Food ≠ Hot

Use *picante* or (in Mexico) *picoso* for spicy.

Examples:

- *La comida está picante.* = The food is spicy.
 - *Está muy picosa.* = It's very spicy. (Mexico)
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9. Weather and Ambient Temperature (Use *hacer*)

Spanish uses *hacer* for weather expressions, literally “it makes heat.”

Examples:

- *Hace calor.* = It's hot.
- *Hace frío.* = It's cold.
- *Hace mucho calor hoy.* = It's very hot today.

This works for both **outside and indoor** temperatures.

Avoid using *estar caliente* for weather—it can sound odd or even inappropriate.

10. Desire with *tener ganas de + infinitive*

This structure means “to feel like doing something.”

Examples:

- *Tengo ganas de ir a la playa.* = I feel like going to the beach.
 - *¿Tienes ganas de salir conmigo?* = Do you feel like going out with me?
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11. Additional Expressions with TENER

These are idiomatic and widely used:

- *Tener sueño* = to be sleepy
 - *Tengo mucho sueño.* = I'm very sleepy.
 - *Tener prisa* = to be in a hurry
 - *Tengo prisa.* = I'm in a hurry.
 - *Tener éxito* = to be successful
 - *Juan tiene mucho éxito.* = Juan is very successful.
 - *Tener suerte* = to be lucky
 - *Tenemos suerte.* = We're lucky.
 - *Tener paciencia* = to have patience
 - *No tengo mucha paciencia.* = I don't have much patience.
 - *Tener la culpa* = to be at fault
 - *No es tu culpa.* = It's not your fault.
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Key Takeaway:

Tener goes far beyond possession in Spanish. It's used to express basic needs, age, physical sensations, weather, emotions, and desires. Learn these patterns and expressions as set chunks—don't try to translate word-for-word. With repetition and practice, they'll become second nature.